

Psalms 102

The Prayer of the Afflicted

A prayer of the afflicted, when he is overwhelmed, and poureth out his complaint before the Lord
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Hear my prayer, O LORD, and let my cry come unto thee.
- 2 Hide not thy face from me in the day when I am in trouble; incline thine ear unto me: in the day when I call answer me speedily.
- 3 For my days are consumed like smoke, and my bones are burned as an hearth.
- 4 My heart is smitten, and withered like grass; so that I forget to eat my bread.
- 5 By reason of the voice of my groaning my bones cleave to my skin.
- 6 I am like a pelican of the wilderness: I am like an owl of the desert.
- 7 I watch, and am as a sparrow alone upon the house top.
- 8 Mine enemies reproach me all the day; and they that are mad against me are sworn against me.
- 9 For I have eaten ashes like bread, and mingled my drink with weeping,
- 10 Because of thine indignation and thy wrath: for thou hast lifted me up, and cast me down.
- 11 My days are like a shadow that declineth; and I am withered like grass.
- 12 But thou, O LORD, shalt endure for ever; and thy remembrance unto all generations.
- 13 Thou shalt arise, and have mercy upon Zion: for the time to favour her, yea, the set time, is come.
- 14 For thy servants take pleasure in her stones, and favour the dust thereof.
- 15 So the heathen shall fear the name of the LORD, and all the kings of the earth thy glory.
- 16 When the LORD shall build up Zion, he shall appear in his glory.
- 17 He will regard the prayer of the destitute, and not despise their prayer.
- 18 This shall be written for the generation to come: and the people which shall be created shall praise the LORD.
- 19 For he hath looked down from the height of his sanctuary; from heaven did the LORD behold the earth;
- 20 To hear the groaning of the prisoner; to loose those that are appointed to death;
- 21 To declare the name of the LORD in Zion, and his praise in Jerusalem;
- 22 When the people are gathered together, and the kingdoms, to serve the LORD.
- 23 He weakened my strength in the way; he shortened my days.
- 24 I said, O my God, take me not away in the midst of my days: thy years are throughout all generations.
- 25 Of old hast thou laid the foundation of the earth: and the heavens are the work of thy hands.
- 26 They shall perish, but thou shalt endure: yea, all of them shall wax old like a garment; as a vesture shalt thou change them, and they shall be changed:
- 27 But thou art the same, and thy years shall have no end.
- 28 The children of thy servants shall continue, and their seed shall be established before thee.

2 · CONTEXT

Explicitly titled as the prayer of one who is afflicted and overwhelmed, Psalm 102 moves through vivid personal suffering—wasting strength, sleepless nights, isolation—into a sweeping vision of God's eternal, unchanging nature and His promised restoration of Zion, before returning briefly to personal frailty and then closing in confidence about God's permanence across generations. Henry highlights how naturally personal affliction and cosmic hope sit side by side here, each making the other more bearable.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The prayer opens with urgent, direct requests: hear my prayer, let my cry come to you, do not hide your face, incline your ear, answer speedily in this day of trouble. Urgency, not eloquence, marks the opening.

Verse 3-11

Suffering is described in unflinching physical and emotional detail: days consumed like smoke, bones burned like a hearth, heart smitten and withered like grass, appetite gone, groaning audible, reduced to skin and bone. Comparisons multiply—like a pelican in the wilderness, an owl in the desert, a sparrow alone on a housetop—while enemies reproach him daily and even use his name as a curse. Ashes for bread and tears mixed with drink complete the picture: days like a fading shadow, withering like grass, with no relief in sight.

Verse 12-17

The lament turns abruptly toward hope grounded in God's nature: but You, Lord, shall endure forever, remembered to all generations. He will arise and have mercy on Zion, for the appointed time to favor her has come; God's own servants take pleasure even in her stones and dust. The nations will fear the Lord's name, kings His glory, when He builds up Zion and appears in His glory, regarding the prayer of the destitute and not despising it—personal affliction and national restoration are held together as evidence of the same character.

Verse 18-22

This will be written down for a generation not yet born, so that people not yet created will praise the Lord—present suffering is framed as something future generations will learn from. God has looked down from His holy height, heard the groaning of the prisoner, and loosed those appointed to death, so that His name may be declared in Zion and praise heard there, as peoples and kingdoms gather to serve the Lord.

Verse 23-24

The lament briefly resurfaces: God has weakened his strength in the way and shortened his days; he pleads, 'do not take me away in the midst of my days,' noting that God's own years span all generations—a final, honest admission that hope in God's eternity has not fully erased the pain of his own mortality.

Verse 25-28

The psalm closes with a majestic contrast: of old God laid the foundation of the earth, and the heavens are the work of His hands; they will perish, but He will endure; they will all grow old like a garment and be changed like clothing, but He is the same, and His years will have no end. The children of His servants will continue, their descendants established before Him—personal frailty absorbed into the permanence of God's own unchanging life and the security it guarantees to those who belong to Him.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Deep, physically embodied affliction and confident hope in God's eternal, unchanging nature are not contradictory postures but companions within the same honest prayer—present suffering does not need to be resolved before hope in God's larger purposes can be voiced. The psalmist's frailty is real and stated without minimizing, yet it is finally absorbed into the permanence of a God whose years have no end and whose care extends even to generations not yet born.

Application for life today.

If you are currently overwhelmed, let this psalm's unflinching physical honesty (vv. 3–11) give you permission to describe your suffering specifically to God rather than in vague, softened terms. Notice that hope here is not the absence of continued pain (vv. 23–24 return to lament even after the vision of restoration)—give yourself room to hold both without forcing premature resolution. Let verse 27's declaration—'but thou art the same'—become an anchor point you return to specifically when your own frailty feels like the whole story.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific, physical language of affliction from verses 3–11 gives you permission to describe your own suffering to God more honestly than you have been?

2. How does this psalm's return to lament (vv. 23–24) even after voicing hope in God's eternal purposes (vv. 12–22) validate a season where hope and pain coexist for you?

3. What would it mean to genuinely rest in 'thou art the same, and thy years shall have no end' (v. 27) as an anchor for a fear about your own limited time or strength?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).